

Eshet Chayil

513a

Version 2

Ben Zion Shenker
Arr. Stuart Izon

Eshet Chayil from chapter 31 of Proverbs is typically sung prior to Kiddush on Friday night. This is a relatively recent custom, introduced by the kabbalists, who interpreted the poem allegorically as a reference to the *Sh'chinah* (the divine presence) or to the Torah. Of course it is also recognised as praise for the lady of the house.

Ben Zion Shenker's melody for *Eshet Chayil* is one of the most iconic Shabbat melodies. Despite its immense popularity, it was only written in 1956, leading many to ponder what other tunes were used for *Eshet Chayil* prior to its introduction. The composition is set in the *Ahava Rabba* (Freygish) mode, with the first section emphasising the augmented interval between the flattened second and the third. The second part of the melody is really just an ornamentation over a descending scale from the sixth to the tonic. The harmonic alternation between the minor 4th and the tonic can lead to misinterpretations of the melody as being in the relative harmonic minor. I notice that many people unwittingly modify the tune for the final line of each verse to recontextualise the melody into the relative harmonic minor. However, Shenker's original composition remains in the Freygish throughout, beginning and ending on the same note.

Lento

Melody Alto

8

E - shet cha-yil mi yim - tza v' - ra - chok mi - p' - ni - nim mich - ra

Tenor Bass

3

M A

8

ba - tach ba lev ba - la v' - sha - lal lo yech - sar g' - ma -

T B

5

M A

8

-lat - hu tov v' - lo ra kol y' - mei cha - ye - ha

T B

7

M
A

8

da - r'-sha tze - mer u - fish - tim va - ta-as b'-che-fetz ka - pe - ha

T
B

9

M
A

8

ha - y' - ta ka - o - ni - yot so - cher mi - mer - chak ta - vi lach - ma v' -

T
B

11

M
A

8

-ta - kom b' - od____ lai - la va - ti - ten te - ref l' - vei - ta v'chok l' - na - a - ro - te - ha

T
B

13

M
A

8

za - m' - ma sa - de va - ti - ka - chei - hu mi - p' - ri cha - pe - ha na - t' - a ka - rem

T
B

15

M
A

8

cha - g' - ra v' - oz mot-ne - ha va - t' - a - metz z' - ro - o - te - ha

T
B

3

3

17

M
A

8

ta - a - ma ki tov sach - ra lo yich - be__ va - lai - la ne - ra ya -

T
B

19

M
A

8

- de - ha shi - l' - cha va - ki - shor v' - cha - pe - ha ta - m' - chu fa - lech

T
B

21

M
A

8

ka - pa pa - r' - sa le - a - ni v' - ya - de - ha shi - l' - cha la - ev - yon lo

T
B

23

M
A

ti - ra l'-vei - ta mi-sha - leg ki kol bei - ta l' - vush sha - nim mar-

T
B

25

M
A

-va - dim a - s' - ta la shesh v' - ar - ga-man l' - vu - sha

T
B

27

M
A

no - da ba-sh'-a-rim ba - la b' - shiv - to im zik - nei a - retz

T
B

29

M
A

sa - din a - s' - ta va - tim - kor va-cha - gor na - t' - na la - k' - na - a - ni

T
B

31

M
A

oz v' - ha - dar l' - vu - sha va - tis - chak l' - yom a - cha - ron

T
B

33

M
A

pi - ha pa - t' - cha v' - choch - ma v' - to - rat che sed al l' - sho - na tzo -

T
B

35

M
A

- fi - a ha - li chot bei - ta v' - le - chem atz - lut lo - to - chel

T
B

37

M
A

ka - mu va - ne - ha - vay - a - sh' - ru - ha ba - la ——— vay - ha - l' - la ra - bot

T
B

39 *rit.*

M A 8

ba - not a - su cha - yil v' - at a - lit al ku - la - na

T B

41 **a tempo**

M A 8

she - ker ha-chen___ v' - he - vel ha-yo - fi i - sha yi-rat a-do-nai___

T B

44

M A 8

hi___ tit - ha - lal___ t' - nu - - la___ mi - p' -

T B

46 *rit.*

M A 8

-ri ya - de - ha vi ha - l' - lu - ha va-sh' - a - rim ma-a-se - ha

T B